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Leisure, Mass Communications and Media

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The leisure–mass communications nexus

Leisure and mass communications have an established and increasingly intimate relationship. The two institutions have developed in parallel and in consort, with communication across time and space essential to the popularization and extension of leisure structures and practices, and the media constituting important sites of leisure in their own right. This chapter will, therefore, focus on two key aspects of the leisure–mass communications nexus. First, it will examine the uses of media as forms of leisure activity such as watching television and film; reading newspapers, magazines and books; listening to recorded music and radio; and ‘surfing’ the internet. Here it can be seen that mass communications and leisure are virtually inseparable in the contemporary world – to the consternation of those who see in this trend a threat to ‘serious’ and ‘healthy’ forms and values of leisure. But the apparatus of mass communications also sometimes takes leisure as its object – the leisure of looking at leisure. Second, therefore, the representation of leisure in the media will be considered and analysed as it appears in such forms as tourist brochures and leisure advertisements, and leisure-oriented television programmes and internet sites. Leisure is also represented and scrutinized, more critically, by the media as a social object in relation to such phenomena as health, the body, sexuality, deviancy, violence, labour, idleness and so on. Here media representations of leisure are the means to the exploration of social issues and, frequently, constructed as opportunities for what Cohen (1980: xx) describes as ‘moral entrepreneurship’, whereby a social problem is identified and solutions proposed under conditions of a self-sustaining ‘moral panic’.

Before pursuing these lines of enquiry, though, it is necessary to examine the evolving relationship between mass communications and leisure. As noted above, the media make many forms of leisure possible, and leisure is a key object of media attention. Leisure Studies, as a field of scholarship, has much in common with Media, Communication and Cultural Studies in its commitment to interdisciplinarity

and concern with the range of interpenetrating structures and processes shaping contemporary social life (Rowe, 2002). It can be difficult to differentiate these approaches, but the consistent thread within Leisure Studies is its orientation around the leisure–work dialectic. The concept of leisure emerged in response to the rationalization of industrial work-time in the nineteenth century (Clarke and Critcher, 1985) and, despite the constant redrawing of the boundaries between, and the content of, work and leisure since then, the utility of the analytical distinction between paid work and leisure as ‘relatively freely undertaken non-work activity’ (Roberts, 1978: 3) remains. The process of mass communication and the services provided by the media have been central to the development of contemporary leisure. Indeed, it can be argued that a progressive ‘mediatization’ of the world has occurred under modernity, as mass communication has become increasingly central to all major (macro and micro) social institutions – political, economic, military, educational, familial, and so on (Curran and Gurevitch, 2000). Whereas the development of mass transport enabled many more people than previously to travel within and between villages, regions and countries, the combination of mass transport and mass communications enabled the media (first in print form, then electronic) to bring the world to increasingly large audiences without ever having to leave home. However, the media’s highly efficient delivery of leisure products – standardized items delivered from a single source to widely dispersed populations (Watson, 1998) – involves more than the availability of new forms of leisure provision. The commercial media are also the ‘display windows’ of the goods and services created in great profusion by the capitalist mode of production.

As leisure became increasingly commodified and industrialized, the old methods of soliciting customers, such as advertising on sandwich boards carried around the streets or through the shouts of traders in marketplaces, could no longer be relied upon. The leisure industries have come to rely on the mass media to connect them to their customer base. The ‘discretionary’ nature of leisure expenditure means that the requirement to prime demand through the media is especially central to the operation of the leisure industries. This task can be achieved through explicit media advertising and promotion, but also as a by-product of media coverage of leisure practices and organizations. By such means the relationship between mass communications and leisure can be shown to be both extensive and intense, overt and hidden, especially when the popular use of media constitutes leisure practice itself.

Mass communications as leisure

The last few centuries, in what we can loosely call the era of modernity – and, now perhaps, the age of postmodernity (Harvey, 1989) – have been characterized by a vast expansion in the institution of the mass media, with knowledge and experience increasingly stored for posterity and communicated to dispersed and disparate human populations. One of the most important existential consequences of this development has been the increased access of larger numbers of people to a widening variety of experiences and to glimpses of ‘other worlds’. This access was